How Memories Become Records

HY6101 Seminar 11 & 12 | Reading Reflection on Moments of Silence

While reading Moments of Silence, I kept wondering: does silence in memory necessarily lead to silence in history? Experiences that a person has not spoken about may still remain in photographs, documents or other people's memories. Yet even when these materials exist, they may not enter public discussion. I am therefore more concerned with the conditions under which personal experiences can be recorded, and with what may prevent them from being recorded. Thongchai's discussion of "unforgetting" makes me want to understand more clearly how memories become records. Many choices in this process are subjective: what different people care about and what they are willing to say will affect the records that are left behind.

In class, the teacher distinguished between silence about historical facts and silence about their implications. This distinction made me think that knowing an event happened does not necessarily mean being willing to acknowledge what it means. The 1996 commemoration discussed in the book allowed more public discussion of the massacre and its violence. But discussion of who carried out the violence, and why, remained restricted.[1] Commemoration opened up space for discussion, but how far could people go? Acknowledging that people suffered and acknowledging who was responsible are different things. How much the state acknowledges, and where it remains silent, will affect how the event is remembered later.

The "chronopolitics" of memory left a strong impression on me. I think time both changes and shapes memory. When people's circumstances and perspectives change, they may understand the same experience differently, even without new evidence. But I think political events already affect memory when it first forms. Social events draw attention to certain things, make some details memorable and shape people's attitudes. The accounts broadcast before the massacre had even ended were already providing a framework for later collective memory.[2] The role of public media and social media also matters to me. For people who did not take part in an event and knew little about it, reporting and the spread of information can direct their attention to particular things. This affects how they later understand and remember the event.

[1] Thongchai Winichakul, Moments of Silence: The Unforgetting of the October 6, 1976, Massacre in Bangkok (Honolulu: University of Hawai'i Press, 2020), chap. 6, "The Commemoration in 1996."

[2] Winichakul, Moments of Silence, chap. 1, "The Unforgetting of October 6," and chap. 3, "The Beginning of Memories."

Thinking about this, I find it hard to see collective memory as simply a collection of personal experiences. Political forces and social conditions also affect how individuals understand, recall and describe their experiences. I do not think a personal memory is "meaningless" just because it falls outside mainstream concerns. But I also accept that once it is recognized as part of collective memory, it is more easily recorded and used. This is also where the difficulty lies: if personal and collective memories focus on different things, how should archives record them? Must an experience be described in familiar terms to make it easier to understand? If this changes what the person originally wanted to express, some of what they meant may still go unheard, even if a record exists.

I am also wondering how official records describe events that ordinary people remember but find difficult to discuss in public. The amnesty bill discussed in the book was influenced by the massacre, yet its wording avoided mentioning the massacre itself. This stands out to me. The names given to events can also reflect different attitudes. Calling the October 1973 uprising the "Day of Extreme Grief" emphasized violence and death, while calling it the "Day of Extreme Joy" emphasized the political outcome.[3] I therefore think we should ask more than whether official documents exist. We also need to examine what the documents included and how they described it. Could what official accounts avoid or leave out also affect ordinary people's memories and their accounts of experiences that are difficult to express? I have not yet worked out an answer to this question.

On the other hand, when the truth about the past is unclear, missing records are not always the reason. Sometimes the relevant records exist, but there are problems with how they are organized, identified and connected. This was the case with the identification of Jaruphong's body in the book. The autopsy reports and photographs existed, but pages and photographs from several reports were in the wrong order, which misled those trying to identify him.[4] This makes me think that a historian's perspective also affects research. Whether historians connect two sources, or think a detail deserves further investigation, affects what can eventually be known. If people later continue to rely on incorrect identifications, categories or descriptions, these will also affect how the experiences of those involved are understood.

The second question in our class group discussion was: how should historians study the meanings and limits of existing historical knowledge? In my view, it is difficult to answer this

[3] Winichakul, Moments of Silence, chap. 4, "The Trial and the Beginning of Silence," and chap. 5, "Disquieting Silence After 1978."

[4] Winichakul, Moments of Silence, chap. 7, "The Good Silence."

question only by interviewing people from that time. First, people's perspectives change over time. The questions a historian prepares before an interview may not be the ones the interviewee considers important. Even when both are discussing the same event, it may be hard to find a common focus. Also, how will the historian record the answers? Choosing what to keep and how to organize and retell it is itself subjective. It is hard to be sure that these choices can escape the limits of the historian's own time. In chapter 9, Thongchai acknowledges that his identity as a former student leader affected his interviews. Some people refused to be interviewed after recognizing him. Others shared thoughts with him that they might not have shared with another interviewer.[5] A different interviewer might have received very different answers.

This also makes me wonder: are the memories of ordinary people and historians affected differently by social and personal factors? Historians have methods for checking and comparing sources, but I do not think this allows them to step completely outside their own circumstances. Thongchai is both a participant and a researcher. He can gain access to certain memories, but at times he does not want to understand his former opponents more deeply. He writes about these limits, but I still want to ask: if historians' questions and records are shaped by their own perspectives, how can they notice choices they do not realize they are making? This makes me pay more attention to the difference between what an interviewee says and what the historian finally writes down.

I think some “silences” do not want to remain silent. Many unspoken experiences are waiting to be expressed and recorded. Efforts to express these silences through commemoration, collecting materials and telling stories also leave new records and create new historical voices. But when I think about those involved, I find it hard to say that more complete records and more public information are always better. In the book, a father's account of his search for his son has no ending. When Thongchai asked the father to continue writing, he realized that the request might cause unbearable pain.[6] For a researcher, this is an unfinished source. For the father, however, the lack of an ending may be linked to a hope he does not want to give up. What the researcher wants to find out may therefore be something the person involved is unwilling to discuss further.

While reading, I also thought about efforts to record the experiences of victims of the Itaewon crowd crush after the event. This event seems very different from the political

[5] Winichakul, Moments of Silence, chap. 9, “Silence of the Wolf.”

[6] Winichakul, Moments of Silence, chap. 7, “The Good Silence.”

violence in the book, but it raises the same question for me: are those involved willing to recall those experiences again? Documenting an event and establishing responsibility may be necessary, but they may also make some people face experiences they do not want to recall. My concern is whether a researcher's wish to preserve the truth could lead them to underestimate this pain. In class, a classmate reflected that telling people who had suffered from war to “move on” could silence them, even if it was meant kindly. I think this connects with my concern. Asking someone to speak, or asking them to stop speaking, may fail to consider their own wishes fully. Respecting their choices is important. But if this means no longer asking questions about the event, questions about responsibility may continue to be avoided. This is also something I find difficult to deal with.

I still cannot say whether archival work should always aim to make as much of the truth about the past public as possible. But I still think that a personal memory does not become meaningless simply because it has not gained collective recognition. Nor does a person's silence mean that this past has been forgotten. How do the perspectives of those making records and the choices of those involved affect the history that is left behind? This is a question I want to keep thinking about.